

Rental Application Fast-Track Checklist — Victoria

Win the lease, even with no rental history or connections.

Correct as at July 2026. General information only, not legal advice. Victoria's rental application rules changed significantly in 2025–26 — this checklist reflects the current framework.

Section 1 — Know Your Rights Before You Apply

- ☐ ☐ **Understand the standardised application form.** From 31 March 2026, rental providers and agents must use the **prescribed rental application form** and can only request the information set out in it — they can no longer ask for anything beyond this standard list.
- ☐ ☐ **Know that rental bidding is banned.** Since 25 November 2025, agents and landlords cannot invite or encourage offers above the advertised rent, and cannot accept an offer above the advertised price. If you're pressured to "offer more" to secure a property, this is not permitted.
- ☐ ☐ **Know your data protection rights.** Applications must be handled with privacy protections, and your information must be deleted within a set period after an unsuccessful application (Consumer Affairs Victoria guidance points to around 14 days for standard cases, with different timeframes possible depending on circumstances) — you're entitled to ask what happens to your data if you're unsuccessful.

Section 2 — Documents to Have Ready Before You Start Applying

- ☐ ☐ **Photo ID** (driver's licence or passport).
- ☐ ☐ **Proof of income** — payslips (usually last 2–4), an employment letter, or for students/those without standard payslips: Centrelink statements, scholarship confirmation, or a parent/guarantor's supporting documents where relevant.
- ☐ ☐ **Rental history/references** — previous landlord or agent contact details, or if you're a first-time renter, alternative references (employer, academic, or personal) that speak to reliability.
- ☐ ☐ **Bank statements** (recent, showing regular income/savings patterns) — not always required under the new prescribed form, but worth having ready since requirements can vary by what's included in the current version.
- ☐ ☐ **A brief cover letter/introduction** — while not part of the formal prescribed form, a short, genuine note about your situation (why this property, your rental intentions, e.g. length of stay) can help you stand out where agents allow supplementary information.

Section 3 — The Application Itself

- ☐ ☐ **Apply promptly after inspecting** — competitive properties in Melbourne can receive many applications within the first day or two of listing.
- ☐ ☐ **Fill out the prescribed form completely** — incomplete applications are often deprioritised regardless of how strong your financial position is.
- ☐ ☐ **Only provide the information the prescribed form actually asks for** — you're entitled to decline requests for anything outside this list, and agents are not permitted to request it.
- ☐ ☐ **Attend the inspection in person if at all possible** — this remains one of the strongest signals of genuine interest, even with online applications now standard.
- ☐ ☐ **Follow up politely, once** — a brief, professional follow-up a few days after applying can help, but avoid repeated contact, which can work against you.

Section 4 — For Students & First-Time Renters Specifically

- ☐ ☐ **Consider a guarantor** if you don't yet have independent income history — many agents will accept a parent or guardian as a guarantor, but confirm this is genuinely accepted by the specific agency before assuming it will help.
- ☐ ☐ **Highlight stability signals** — enrolment confirmation, course length, or a stable casual work history can help demonstrate reliability even without a long rental history.
- ☐ ☐ **Consider co-applying with reliable housemates** — a joint application with combined stable income/references is often stronger than several separate uncertain applications.
- ☐ ☐ **Don't be discouraged by rejections** — competitive rental markets mean even strong applications are often unsuccessful; apply for multiple properties in parallel rather than waiting on one outcome.

Section 5 — Red Flags to Watch For as an Applicant

- ☐ ☐ **Any request to pay more than the advertised rent to secure the property** — this is banned; you can report this to Consumer Affairs Victoria.
- ☐ ☐ **Requests for information outside the prescribed application form** — you're entitled to ask why it's needed and can decline.
- ☐ ☐ **Pressure to pay money before an application is even approved** (beyond a holding deposit in specific, legally compliant circumstances) — get advice from Consumer Affairs Victoria if this happens.

Quick Reference — Key 2025-26 VIC Rental Application Rules

RULE	DETAIL
Prescribed application form	Mandatory from 31 March 2026 — agents can only request listed information
Rental bidding ban	In effect since 25 November 2025 — no offers above advertised rent
Data deletion for unsuccessful applicants	Required within a set short timeframe — ask the agent for specifics

